Ownership

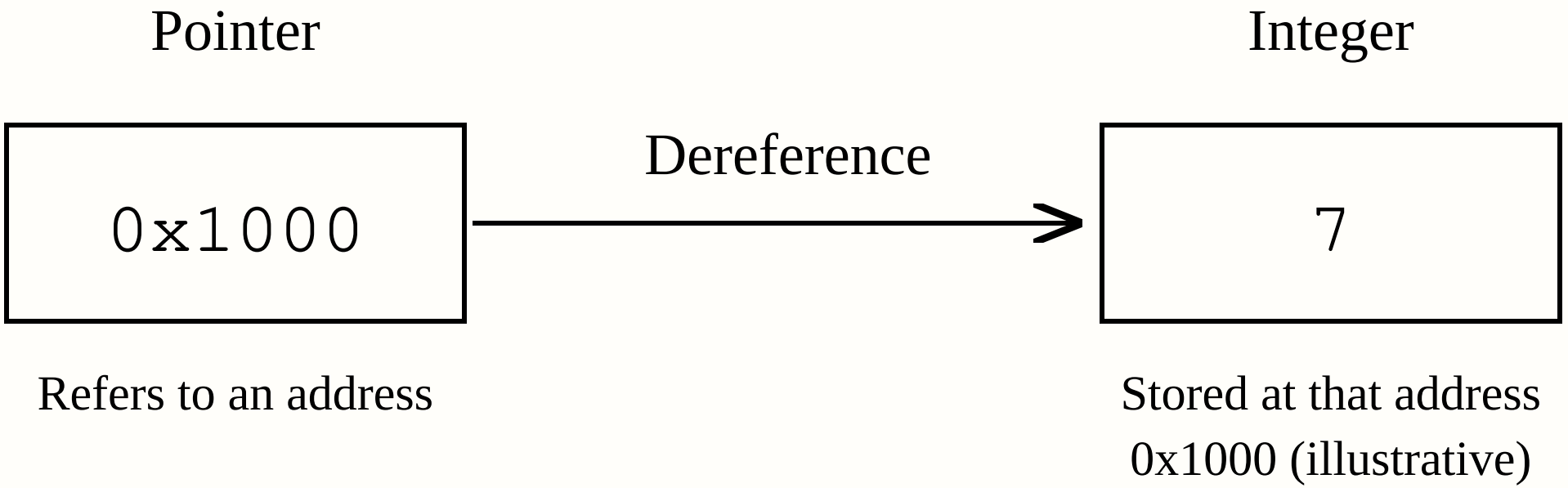
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Values and resources

- Ownership of values and responsibility for cleanup
- Moves, copies, and explicit duplication
- Destruction and resource lifetime
- Borrowed access without ownership transfer

Pointers



- Sometimes we need to share a piece of memory
- Pointers let us observe remote state, and possibly mutate it (woo, dangerous!)

Stack and heap

- The **stack** holds temporary storage for active function calls
- Each call adds a **frame** for its local data
- Returning from a call releases its frame
- The **heap** holds separate blocks allocated while the program runs
- A heap block lasts until released, possibly after the allocating call returns

Resource lifetime

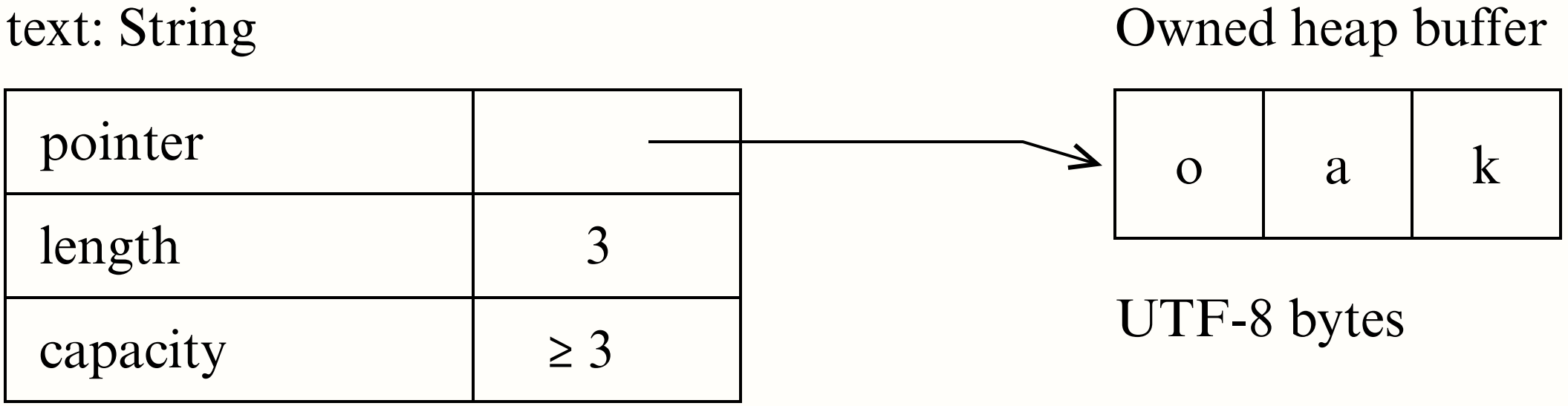
- Allocated memory, open files, held locks
- Access after release uses an invalid resource
- Two independent releases cause double cleanup
- Compile-time ownership and borrowing rules for valid access

Values and bindings

```
fn main() {
    let text = String::from("oak");
    println!("{}", text.len());
}
```

- A local `text` binding containing a `String`
- The `String` owns a buffer of UTF-8 bytes

Owned storage



- Length counts bytes in use, capacity measures allocated space
- Conceptual fields without a specified field order

Storage and ownership

- Local values usually occupy space in the stack frame
- `String` and `Vec<T>` own heap buffers
- Ownership rules apply to heap-free values too
- The compiler decides storage placement and machine copies

Structs

```
struct Point { x: i32, y: i32 }
fn main() {
    let mut point = Point { x: 3, y: 4 };
    point.x += 1;
    println!("{} {}", point.x, point.y);
}
```

- A user-defined type with named, typed fields
- Fields belong to the struct value, without a separate allocation

Scope

```
fn main() {
    {
        let text = String::from("oak");
        println!("{}", text.len());
    }
}
```

- The local value is dropped at the end of its scope
- Dropping this `String` releases its buffer

Ownership transfer

```
fn main() {
    let first = String::from("oak");
    let second = first;
    println!("{second}");
}
```

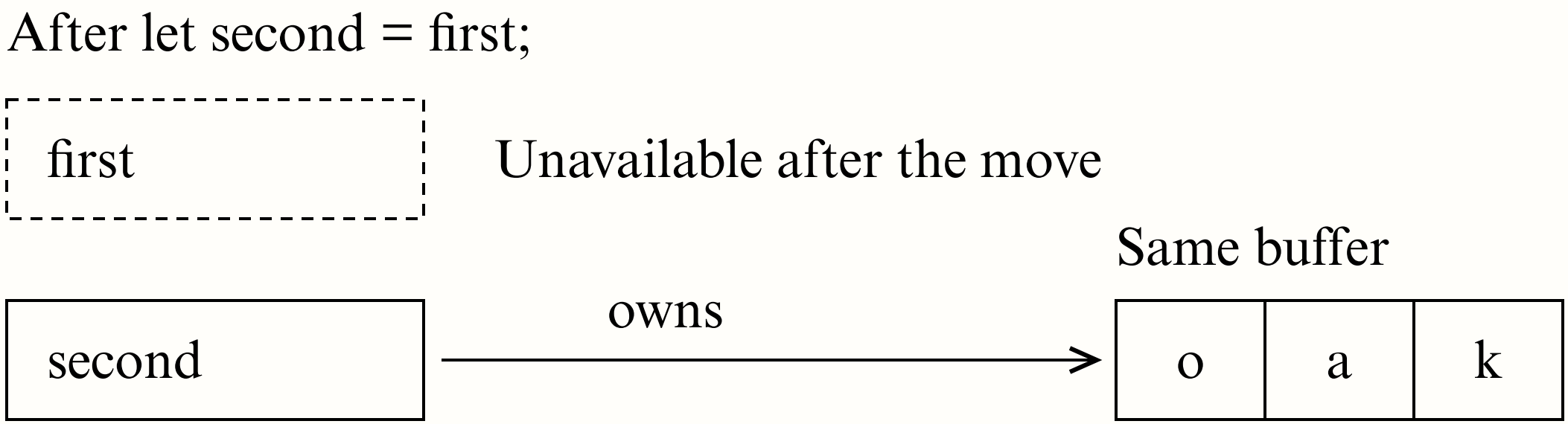
- Assignment moves a non-`Copy` value
- `second` now owns the string

Use after move

```
fn main() {
    let first = String::from("oak");
    let second = first;
    println!("{second}");
    println!("{first}");
}
```

- E0382 reports use of a moved value

String move



- Ownership transfer without duplicating the buffer
- The old binding has no value available for use or drop

Boxed values

```
fn main() {
    let first = Box::new(7);
    let mut second = first;
    *second += 1;
    println!("{second}");
}
```

- `Box<T>` owns a heap-allocated `T`
- Moving the box transfers ownership of the allocation
- Dropping the box drops `T` and releases the allocation

Moves without allocation

```
struct Token;
fn main() {
    let first = Token;
    let _second = first;
    let _third = first;
}
```

- `Token` is a unit struct with no fields
- Even a zero-sized type is non-`Copy` by default

Reinitialization

```
fn main() {
    let mut first = String::from("oak");
    let second = first;
    first = String::from("elm");
    println!("{first} {second}");
}
```

- A moved binding can receive a new value

Owned parameters

```
fn byte_len(text: String) -> usize {
    text.len()
}
fn main() {
    let name = String::from("oak");
    println!("{}", byte_len(name));
}
```

- The argument moves into the parameter, which is dropped on return

Return values

```
fn name() -> String {
    let text = String::from("oak");
    text
}
fn main() {
    let result = name();
    println!("{result}");
}
```

- Returning the value transfers ownership to the caller

Implicit copies

```
fn main() {
    let first = 7;
    let mut second = first;
    second += 1;
    println!("{first} {second}");
}
```

- `i32` implements `Copy`, so both bindings have usable values

Copy as a type property

- Implicit, bitwise duplication in value contexts
- Integers, floats, `bool`, `char`, tuples and arrays of `Copy` elements
- Explicit implementation or derivation for user-defined types
- Type size and stack placement do not decide whether a type is `Copy`

Derived Copy

```
#[derive(Clone, Copy)]
struct Pair(i32, i32);
fn main() {
    let first = Pair(3, 4);
    let second = first;
    println!("{} {}", first.0, second.1);
}
```

- `Pair` is a tuple struct with fields `.0` and `.1`
- Every field must be `Copy`, and the type cannot implement `Drop`

Explicit duplication

```
fn main() {
    let first = String::from("oak");
    let mut second = first.clone();
    second.push('s');
    println!("{first} {second}");
}
```

- `String::clone` creates a separate owned buffer with the same contents

Move, copy, clone

- A **move** transfers ownership and makes the source value unavailable
- A **copy** duplicates the value implicitly
- A **clone** duplicates it through a type-defined operation
- Cloning may allocate or share a resource through a shared pointer

Partial moves

```
fn main() {
    let pair = (String::from("L"), String::from("R"));
    let left = pair.0;
    println!("{left} {}", pair.1);
}
```

- Moving one field leaves the other field available

Whole value after a partial move

```
fn main() {
    let pair = (String::from("L"), String::from("R"));
    let _left = pair.0;
    println!("{pair:?}");
}
```

- E0382 reports that the whole tuple is no longer available

Conditional moves

```
fn main() {
    let text = String::from("oak");
    if text.len() > 2 {
        let _taken = text;
    }
    println!("{text}");
}
```

- A value must be available on every path reaching its use

Destruction

- Initialized local values are dropped at scope exit
- Local bindings are dropped in reverse declaration order
- Owned fields are dropped recursively
- Implement `Drop` for additional type-specific cleanup

Observable drop order

```
struct Trace(u8);
impl Drop for Trace {
    fn drop(&mut self) { print!("{} ", self.0); }
}
fn main() {
    let _outer = Trace(1);
    { let _inner = Trace(2); }
    print!("end ");
}
```

- Inner scope first, then the remaining outer local

Early release

```
fn main() {
    let text = String::from("oak");
    drop(text);
    println!("{text}");
}
```

- `std::mem::drop` takes its argument by value
- E0382 follows from transferring ownership into `drop`

Replacement

```
struct Trace(u8);
impl Drop for Trace {
    fn drop(&mut self) { print!("{} ", self.0); }
}
fn main() {
    let mut value = Trace(1);
    value = Trace(2);
    print!("body ");
    drop(value);
}
```

- Assignment drops the old value before storing the new one

Resource management

- Cleanup follows ownership, including ordinary early returns
- Unwinding cleans up initialized values on the unwound path
- Process exit and abort can skip destructors
- Memory safety does not imply freedom from resource leaks

Borrowed access

```
fn main() {
    let value = 7;
    let view = &value;
    println!("{} {value}", *view);
}
```

- Borrow with `&value` and access the referent through `*view`
- Borrowing leaves ownership with the original owner

Shared references

```
fn main() {
    let text = String::from("oak");
    let first = &text;
    let second = first;
    println!("{first} {second}");
}
```

- `&T` is `Copy`, even when `T` is not
- Copying a reference does not duplicate the owned value

Mutable references

```
fn main() {
    let mut value = 7;
    let view = &mut value;
    *view += 1;
    println!("{value}");
}
```

- `&mut T` provides exclusive access and is not `Copy`
- The reference binding itself need not be `mut`

Methods

```
struct Counter { value: u32 }
impl Counter {
    fn value(&self) -> u32 { self.value }
}
fn main() {
    let counter = Counter { value: 7 };
    println!("{}", counter.value());
}
```

- Define methods in an `impl` block
- `&self` borrows the receiver, automatically in `counter.value()`

Mutating methods

```
struct Counter { value: u32 }
impl Counter {
    fn increment(&mut self) { self.value += 1; }
}
fn main() {
    let mut counter = Counter { value: 7 };
    counter.increment();
    println!("{}", counter.value);
}
```

- `&mut self` requires exclusive access to the receiver

Consuming methods

```
struct Label { text: String }
impl Label {
    fn into_text(self) -> String { self.text }
}
fn main() {
    let label = Label { text: String::from("oak") };
    let text = label.into_text();
    println!("{text}");
}
```

- `self` takes the receiver by value, moving this non-`Copy` label

Mutable bindings

```
fn main() {
    let first = 1;
    let second = 2;
    let mut view = &first;
    print!("{view} ");
    view = &second;
    println!("{view}");
}
```

- `mut view` permits reassignment of the binding, not mutation through `&T`

Conflicting access

```
fn main() {
    let mut text = String::from("oak");
    let view = &text;
    text.push('s');
    println!("{view}");
}
```

- E0502 reports shared access overlapping the mutable access in `push`

Last use of a borrow

```
fn main() {
    let mut text = String::from("oak");
    let view = &text;
    print!("{view} ");
    text.push('s');
    println!("{text}");
}
```

- The borrow can end after its last use, before the binding's scope ends

Exclusive access

```
fn main() {
    let mut value = 7;
    let first = &mut value;
    let second = &mut value;
    println!("{first} {second}");
}
```

- E0499 reports overlapping mutable borrows of the same value

Reborrowing

```
fn main() {
    let mut value = 7;
    let outer = &mut value;
    let inner = &mut *outer;
    *inner += 1;
    *outer += 1;
    println!("{value}");
}
```

- Access through `outer` resumes after the last use of `inner`

Overlapping reborrows

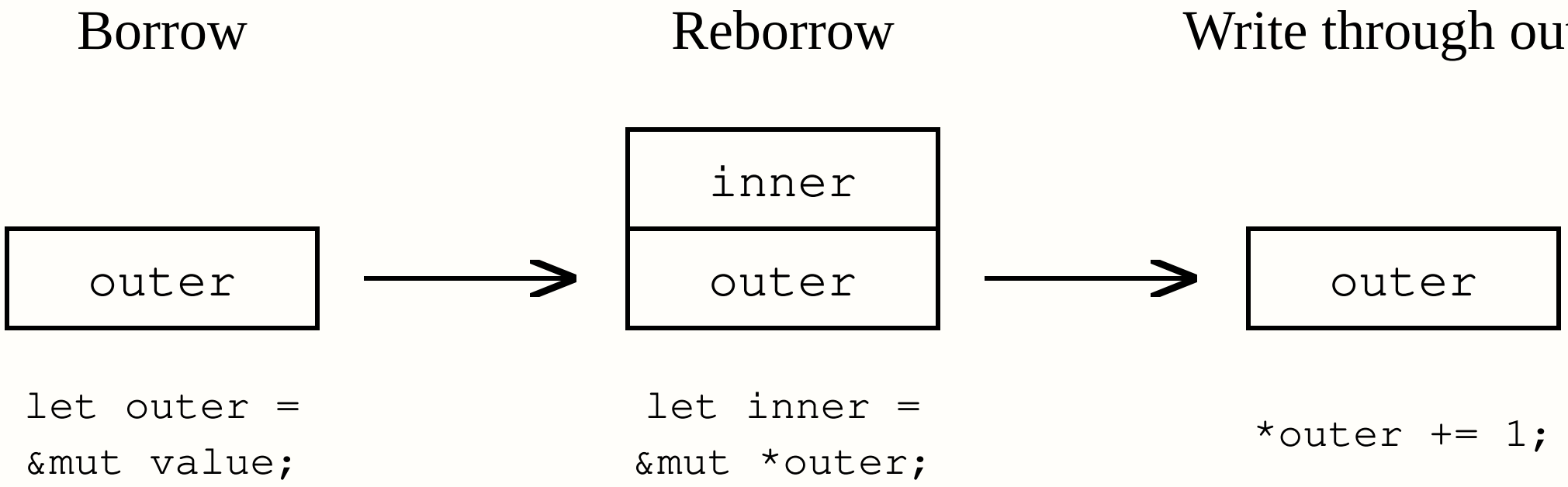
```
fn main() {
    let mut value = 7;
    let outer = &mut value;
    let inner = &mut *outer;
    *outer += 1;
    println!("{inner}");
}
```

- The later use of `inner` keeps its exclusive borrow active

Stacked Borrows

- An experimental model of valid reference and pointer access
- Tagged access permissions in a stack for each memory location
- Access through an older exclusive borrow can invalidate newer borrows
- Implemented in Miri alongside Tree Borrows, not the Rust language specification

Reborrow permissions



- A simplified trace for the exclusive reborrow example
- Using `inner` after the final write would violate this model

Reference lifetime

```
fn main() {
    let view;
    {
        let text = String::from("oak");
        view = &text;
    }
    println!("{view}");
}
```

- E0597 requires the referent to exist for every use of the reference

Owned strings and string slices

- `String` owns a growable UTF-8 buffer
- `&str` borrows UTF-8 bytes and records their length
- String literals refer to text in static storage
- Borrowed views do not allocate or extend the owner’s lifetime

String slices

```
fn main() {
    let text = String::from("red green");
    let prefix = &text[..3];
    println!("{prefix} {text}");
}
```

- Slice indices are byte offsets
- String slice boundaries must be valid UTF-8 boundaries

Sequence slices

```
fn main() {
    let values = vec![10, 20, 30];
    let tail = &values[1..];
    println!("{tail:?}");
}
```

- `&[T]` borrows contiguous elements and records their length
- One owned buffer, accessed through a smaller view

Vector growth

```
fn main() {
    let mut values = Vec::with_capacity(4);
    values.push(10);
    let first = &values[0];
    values.push(20);
    println!("{first}");
}
```

- `push` requires `&mut Vec<T>`, even with spare capacity
- Its signature requires exclusive access, rather than a proof of reallocation

Borrowed parameters

```
fn byte_len(text: &str) -> usize { text.len() }
fn main() {
    let owned = String::from("oak");
    let length = byte_len(&owned);
    println!("{length} {}", byte_len("elm"));
}
```

- A `&str` parameter accepts a borrowed `String` or a string literal

Borrowed results

```
fn trimmed(text: &str) -> &str { text.trim() }
fn main() {
    let owned = String::from(" oak ");
    let view = trimmed(&owned);
    println!("{view}");
}
```

- The result borrows the input without allocating a new string
- Lifetime elision relates the result to the single input borrow

Lifetime parameters

```
fn trimmed<'a>(text: &'a str) -> &'a str {
    text.trim()
}
fn main() {
    let owned = String::from(" oak ");
    println!("{}", trimmed(&owned));
}
```

- `'a` names the borrow lifetime shared by input and result
- An annotation relates borrows without extending the owner's lifetime

Lifetime elision

- Omitted lifetime parameters follow rules in the signature
- Each elided input lifetime gets a distinct parameter
- With exactly one input lifetime, elided outputs use that lifetime
- The function body is checked against the resulting signature

Ambiguous output lifetime

```
fn choose(left: &str, right: &str) -> &str {
    if left.len() >= right.len() { left } else { right }
}
fn main() {
    println!("{}", choose("oak", "elm"));
}
```

- E0106 requires a lifetime for the result
- Neither input lifetime is selected by elision

Explicit output lifetime

```
fn choose<'a>(left: &'a str, right: &'a str) -> &'a str {
    if left.len() >= right.len() { left } else { right }
}
fn main() {
    let left = String::from("oak");
    println!("{}", choose(&left, "elm"));
}
```

- Both inputs must be valid for the chosen `'a`
- The owners can have different scopes

Borrowing methods

```
struct Text { value: String }
impl Text {
    fn before(&self, separator: &str) -> &str {
        self.value.split(separator).next().unwrap()
    }
}
fn main() {
    let text = Text { value: String::from("oak,elm") };
    println!("{}", text.before(","));
}
```

- The returned slice borrows `self`, not `separator`

Receiver lifetime elision

```
fn before(&self, separator: &str) -> &str

fn before<'a, 'b>(
    &'a self, separator: &'b str,
) -> &'a str
```

- Equivalent method signatures inside `impl Text`
- With `&self` or `&mut self`, elided outputs use the receiver's lifetime
- Other borrowed arguments can have independent lifetimes

Ownership in signatures

```
fn inspect(text: &str) { /* shared access */ }
fn change(text: &mut String) { /* exclusive access */ }
fn consume(text: String) { /* owned input */ }
fn create() -> String { String::new() }
```

- Shared access, exclusive access, or ownership transfer
- The signature expresses the caller's obligations

Ownership choices

- Borrow for temporary access
- Transfer ownership when the recipient needs the value
- Clone when a second owned value is needed
- Return an owned value for newly created data

Ownership model

- One owner at a time for each owned value
- Ownership transfer by move or duplication through `Copy` and `Clone`
- Cleanup of the values still owned at destruction
- Shared or exclusive access bounded by borrow lifetimes

References

- *Understanding Ownership in The Rust Book*
- *Destructors in the Rust Reference*
- *`Copy` and `Clone`*
- *`String` representation*
- *`Vec` guarantees*

Further reading

- *Structs and methods in The Rust Book*
- `Box<T>`
- *Lifetime elision in the Rust Reference*
- *Stacked Borrows model*
- *Miri and its aliasing models*